INFORMATION MAP

COLLECTION CONTEMPORARY ART 1975 – PRESENT

THIS FLOOR EXPLORES ART FROM THE SPANISH TRANSITION PERIOD TO THE PRESENT DAY, FOLLOWING THREE LINEAR ROUTES. THIS MAP CAN SERVE AS A GUIDE.

2026

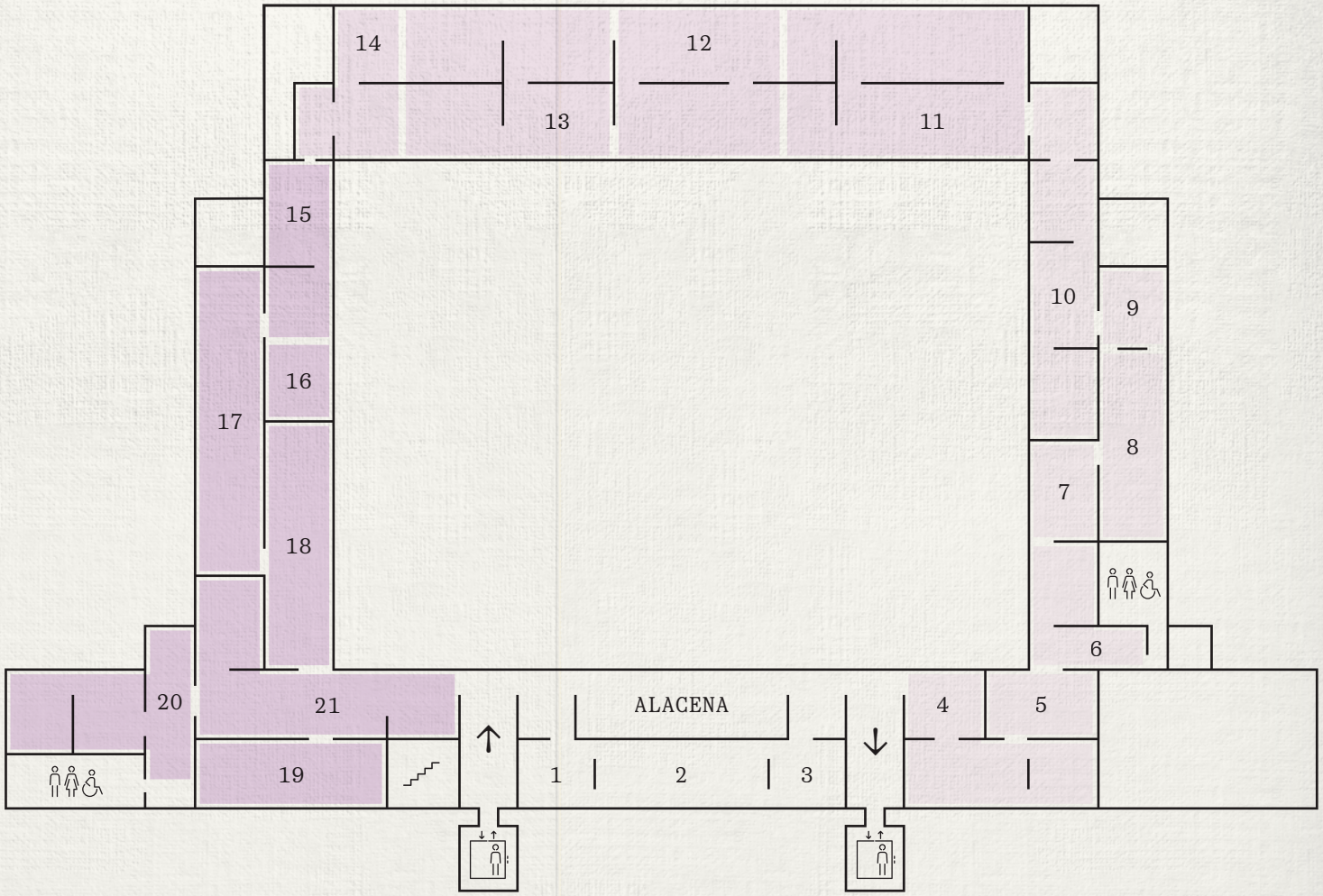


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FLOOR 4

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2. Material Counterculture
3. Attempts at and Limits of an Institutional Regime for Art in Democracy

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Juan Genovés, *Document No. ...*, 1975

This floor tells the history of art of the last fifty years through a selection of works from the Museo Reina Sofía's collections. Is the past the path that leads to the present, or does its memory offer mistakes and paths of no return when faced with a future still to build? Or better yet, how does one travel back to the past from the present? The work of a national museum is not to reinterpret the past in search of a mirror for today's society, but rather to let the concerns of the present find a multitude of responses in the past so as to understand that the present day is not something to be taken as a given, but rather as a becoming that is indispensably constructed as a collective. In uncertain times, it is not a question of imagining futures, but of trying to recognize in the present those desirable futures that are already here.

Contemporary art arose as an order of representation, a transformation of culture and the history of ideas, emerging as a systemic critique of modernity. Its development happened in parallel with a number of sociohistorical changes, beginning in the late 1960s and continuing to develop to the present day. Countercultural movements broadened the boundaries of sensibility and taste, giving rise to new counter-audiences. Second-wave feminism shook masculine domination, sending ripples throughout the gender system as a whole and making the representation of the body a site of conflict. Environmental awareness began to highlight the problems of unchecked development of production processes and extractivism, with its global consequences and exponential risk. The decolonization processes of countries in the global South changed not only the

world's political geography but also its demographic flows over the last fifty years.

This floor provides a number of approaches to contemporary art from Spain. Since the 1970s, when the slow, collective construction of democracy began, Spanish society has evolved toward a boundless diversity in which art has played a fundamental role. Historical temporality is never uniform nor linear, but is rather made up of a series of complex processes, often presaged, often disjointed in time. Thus, this presentation features anachronisms and the coexistence of different moments, following three routes that return over and over again to the 1970s. Similarly, local geographical space is not a closed context, but rather a site of intersection and circulation of cultural manifestations. The Museo Reina Sofía's intention is to share these stories as possibilities and as working tools for future presentations, so that the collections can remain permanently open to renovation.



Room 8

A HISTORY OF AFFECT IN CONTEMPORARY ART

In an era of extreme emotionality, the public exhibitionism of social media, and the blurring of boundaries between fiction and reality, affects are central to the production of meaning. Affective systems were crucially important for the first generation of conceptual artists, especially those creators linked to international second-wave feminism who brought women's bodies into the public arena as the site for their work on representation.

The new social presences in the 1970s also saw the emergence of likewise unexplored affective relationalities, especially within society's seemingly marginal spaces. The loving uses of the new sexual freedoms, the systems of meaning that construct different subcultural

communities, the intensity of new psychoactive substances and their addictions, and the proliferation of a shared, global image culture in late capitalism have had profound effects on the languages of art.

In the mid-1980s, it was the AIDS pandemic, which hit Spain at the same time as a heroin epidemic, that shook the system of affects to its core. Grief, no longer felt individually but collectively, shared by groups of people who were complete strangers, became the norm of social experience. The world order transformed in 2001 by the 9/11 terrorist attacks and the related Madrid bombings in 2004 produced a new reality in which fiction seemed to have triumphed over the real. And yet grief is a stubborn emotion and an especially useful tool as social glue; it can perhaps remind us of the purpose behind what unites us as a society.



Room 14

THE POWERS OF FICTION: SCULPTURE, NEW MATERIALISMS, AND RELATIONAL AESTHETICS

In the 1980s, as contemporary art expanded its affective capacities, it recovered a material condition that had been growing exponentially in previous decades. The primary affective sense is touch, and if each artistic period has its own overriding sense, this one is tactile, giving primacy to things and bodies. Objects are networks of relationships at a moment in time, crystallizing sociohistorical relations of production. Bodies are links for those relationalities. So isn't the exhibition space a reality expressly designed for the encounter between bodies and things, in which to make those relationships legible and historical?

This route is a sculptural gallery. Sculpture physically coexists in the same space as the visitor: it breaks down the barriers between fiction and reality. The new Spanish sculpture of the 1980s had an enormous international impact, especially through female artists such as Susana Solano and Cristina Iglesias. In recent years, a new generation of young female sculptors has again come to the fore internationally, representing the most significant contribution to present-day Spanish art.

This path through the gallery empowers the visitor: to perceive transformations in the logic of the world's objects and their relationships with people; to experience sculpture's undeniable performativity, readable only in the act of moving beyond a singular perspective; to glimpse new materialities, forms that are still emerging and even speculative; and, lastly, to imagine fresh institutionalities through sculpture thanks to relational aesthetics, a set of artistic practices that require a community's participation in order to be carried out.



Room 17

A NEW FRAMEWORK: THE INSTITUTION, THE MARKET, AND THE ART THAT TRANSCENDS BOTH

In the early 1980s, work began on building an institutional cultural fabric that sought to combine the living memory of the return from exile with the international context. The Museo Reina Sofía was founded as an art center in Madrid's former Hospital General de San Carlos in 1986.

The emergence of a new and aspirational taste, the effects of institutionalization, and the opening of a new market resulted in unequal attention being paid to different artistic disciplines. Painting reached a pinnacle of critical enthusiasm in the late 1970s, culminating in a commercial explosion of its expressionist facet in the 1980s. Video art was nurtured in independent

circles and its entry into institutions came late, but it sparked a renewal in forms of audiovisual production. Photography grew as a medium in both publishing and exhibition formats throughout the 1980s, becoming the preferred tool for revealing the constructed nature of reality in an image culture.

As the 2000s progressed, the translation of conceptualism into criticism of representation consolidated the figure of the multidisciplinary artist, treated ironically in Carles Congost's video that tells of the exploits of a soccer player who decides to abandon the sport to become a video artist. The symptoms of a need for renewing tradition and rectifying flagrant omissions in art history also serve to expand the boundaries of convention. As democratic institutions, museums respond to the efforts by new social presences to gain visibility within a contemporary art that was shaped by the identity-based conflicts that ravaged the twentieth century and that are becoming a central aspect of social coexistence in the twenty-first century.



Esther Ferrer, *Intimate and Personal*, 1977.
Atélier Lerin, Paris. Photography: Ethel Blum

This presentation of the Museo Reina Sofía collection was a collaborative effort directed by Manuel Segade Lodeiro. The Deputy Artistic Director was Amanda de la Garza Mata, with Ana Uruñuela Olloqui coordinating the installation and Carolina Bustamante Gutiérrez providing support, while the narratives were crafted together with the Collections team: Beatriz Alonso, Silvia Ariño Gurrea, Cristina Cámara Bello, Concha Calvo Salanova, Lorena Canela Forero, Cèlia Cuenca, Almudena Díez García, Lucía Delgado Porras, Carmen Fernández Aparicio, Ruth Gallego Fernández, Lola Hinojosa Martínez, José Manuel Lara Oliveros, María Teresa López Flores, Raúl Martínez Arranz, Joaquín Merlos Isidro, Alba Muñoz Córdoba, Sonia Pastor, María Rosario Peiró Carrasco, María Pérez Garijo, Juan Carlos Rodríguez Pérez, Francisco Rojas Serrano, Suset Sánchez Sánchez, and María del Pilar de la Vega Puente. The Collections team likewise produced the texts that accompany the route.

The moving of the exhibited pieces was managed and coordinated by the Office of the Registrar team, consisting of Alessia Facchin Díaz, María Victoria Fernández-Layos Moro, Raquel Gómez del Val, Sofía Illana López, Laura Molina Rincón, Elvira Moya San Martín, Begoña Muro Martín Corral, Julia Nicolás Hernández, Mª Ángeles Rincón Díaz, Marina Ruiz Díez, Alicia Serrano Pérez, Pureza Villaescuerna Ilarraza, and Guillermo Villaumbrales Martínez, under the leadership of Maria Aránzazu Borraz de Pedro.

Conservation monitoring and restoration of the pieces were undertaken by the Museo Reina Sofía's Conservation-Restoration team, comprising Margarita Brañas Lasala, Paula Ercilla Orbañanos, Irene García Bustos, Eugenia Gimeno Pascual, Manuela Gómez Rodríguez, Belén González Hernández, Ana Iruretagoyena García, Begoña Juárez Marcos, Silvia Montero Redondo, Gemma Portolés Falgàs, Regina Rivas Tornés, Juan Antonio Sáez Dégano, Virginia Uriarte Padró, Arianne Vanrell Vellosillo, and Roberto Zabala Martín-Gil, headed by Jorge Arcadio García Gómez-Tejedor.

The Library and Documentation Centre; Editorial Activities; Security; Architecture, Sustainable Development and General Services; and the Economic Departments, as well as other areas of the Deputy Management all contributed their specialist knowledge to various aspects of the project.

The installation was designed by artist Xabier Salaberria and architect Patxi Eguiluz.

Graphic design was created by Hermanos Berenguer, with adaptations by ferranElOtro Studio.

Installation in the exhibition halls was realized by teams from Rees.

The audiovisual installation was undertaken by the firm Zenit.

The Museum thanks the artists who have collaborated in the installation of their works and all those who have contributed to expanding the collections, whether donors, former Museum directors and employees, or officials from the Spanish Ministry of Culture.

Cover image: Chumy Chúmez (José María González Castrillo), Cover of *Hermano Lobo* (Wolf Brother), year 4, no. 185, November 22, 1975. Biblioteca y Centro de Documentación. Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofía

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OPENING TIMES

Monday to Saturday: 10 a.m. – 9 p.m.
Free: 7 – 9 p.m.

Sunday: 10 a.m – 2:30 p.m.
Free: 12:30 – 2:30 p.m.

Tuesday: closed

Last admission:
30 minutes before closing time

Clearance:
15 minutes before closing time

ALACENA

Meeting point and seating area

EDUCATION–MEDIATION

Guided tours

ACCESIBILITY

At the Assistance/Information Desks (Floors 1 and 2):

- Wheelchairs
- Folding cane seats (also on Floor 4)

At the Audio Guide Desks (Floor 1):

- Audio guides
- Audio guides (audio descriptions / Spanish Sign Language)
- Magnetic induction loops
- Radio guides

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